Doing DH with Omeka: a Mini-con for Omeka Users and Developers

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The Omeka project , including Omeka Classic, Omeka.net, and Omeka S, is a set of free and open-source web-publishing platforms designed for cultural heritage organizations and researchers to make digitized materials more discoverable, interactive and meaningful for members of the public and experts alike. Its user-friendliness, modular design, interoperability, and focus on accessibility make it a powerful tool for engaging citizens in knowledge creation, preservation, and dissemination. To date, over 50% of the add-ons for the Omeka platforms come for the larger developer community, which is quite an achievement for a centrally managed open source project, and is a testament to the energy around the platforms. We propose a mini-conference to accompany DH2025 that will offer a valuable opportunity for the Omeka user and developer communities to forge much-needed connections and to discuss how we can continue to use the software to create better access to heritage materials.

Launched in February 2008, Omeka Classic remains the backbone of the Omeka project, and is the software provided through the Omeka.net hosting infrastructure, which offers the software as a service for over 100,000 users who do not have the capability to or interest in hosting their own work. While usage numbers are always difficult to calculate with open source software, our best estimates suggest that the software has been downloaded or one-click installed over 500,000 times in its lifetime. Currently, there are full or partial translations of the software in 79 languages.

Omeka S is the next generation of Omeka development. Launched in November 2017, the software is designed for medium to large institutions who need to manage many sites, or for any user who wants to capitalize on the software's ability to easily publish linked descriptive data. The Omeka S software is built with sustainability in mind. All data and media housed within the platform is built on its own application programming interfaces, which makes these materials accessible to import and export. The platform's support for linked open data ensures scientific resources can be shared and connected to external resources like Wikidata, Europeana and other open repositories, enhancing the context of digital collections. Furthermore, the user interfaces are designed to contemporary accessibility standards so are available to assistive technologies and web archiving tools. Since the first alpha release, the software has been downloaded 100,000 times. It has developed a strong user base in the library and museum communities around the world.

By helping build access to digital collections, over the years the Omeka platforms have greatly helped (digital) historians, archaeologists, heritage specialists, and educators create a range of citizen science projects. Through Omeka's user-friendly tools, digital humanists can easily involve the public in engaging tasks like cataloging artifacts, transcribing documents, or annotating images. Various search and filter options enable dynamic exploration and discovery of data, cultural heritage materials, and interpretive context.

Several projects offer examples of the range of work that the Omeka platforms make possible:

- At the Henri Poincaré Archives (Nancy, France), researchers are working in collaboration with archivists on a platform (launch scheduled for February 2025) leveraging the flexibility of Omeka S to describe archival documents using the new standard Records in Contexts (RiC).
- In collaboration with KADOC KU Leuven and PARCUM, LIBIS developed an online participatory platform ' Chapels in Flanders '. This website offers a rich inventory of chapels in Flanders with links to external databases and geographical functionalities. In addition, the general public is involved in the inventory

thanks to Omeka's crowdsourcing functionality.
- The On These Grounds project uses Omeka S to publish and aggregate linked open data derived from archival collections that describes the lived experiences of enslaved people who labored for colleges and universities in the United States.

Recently, key clusters of Omeka users and developers have gathered to share their experiences and insights. The Association des Usagers Francophones d'Omeka is strong and gathers for an annual meeting in December. In Fall 2023, a group of two dozen Omeka S developers gathered for two days at Ghent University to discuss their use of the software and possible future developments. These events suggest that there is strong interest in bringing together Omeka users, designers, and developers to grow the collaborative community, and a mini-con at DH2025 will be an ideal site to broaden the accessibility of these collaborations to include the whole of the interest community of digital humanists.

This in-person mini-con, open to interested registrants for DH2025, will bring together novice and experienced users of the Omeka platforms, and designers and developers who work with the software to share their knowledge and experiences creating well-described, publicly accessible repositories of digitized cultural heritage materials and with mobilizing those materials to communicate sophisticated interpretation. During the day-long meeting, participants will have the opportunity to discuss their work, make plans for future projects, develop community relationships, and learn from one another.

Tentative Agenda

The following agenda is tentative and is due to change based on the needs of the community, and can be adapted based on the facilities and participants available at the conference.

MORNING SESSION (3.5 hours)
Plenary Session

- Registration & Coffee (30 minutes)
- Welcome & Opening Remarks (15 minutes)
- Panel session: Structuring Omeka community and organizations around the world (1 hour)
- Lightning Talks: Project & Add-ons Showcase (1.75 hours)

LUNCH BREAK (1.5 hours)
AFTERNOON SESSION (3.5 hours)
Ask the expert (1.25 hour)

- Working session matching novice users with experts in their area of interest to provide advice

Unconference Affinity Working Group Sessions (1.75 hours)

- Session 1
  - Working with archaeological materials and 3D modeling
  - Creating and managing archival description
  - Community engagement and digital public history work
- Session 2
  - Integrating Omeka into the Digital Humanities classroom
  - Geospatial methods
  - Best practices in working with linked open data

Closing Plenary (30 minutes)

- Brief remarks from the Omeka team on current developments and future plans

Optional evening: Networking gathering/Regional meet-ups (casual gatherings at local bars/restaurants)